A KEYNOTE ADDRESS AND HOMILY

AT

THE ANNUAL CONVENTION OF THE CANON LAW SOCIETY OF NIGERIA, ENUGU

27th-30th OCTOBER, 2026.

TITLE:A KEYNOTE ADDRESS AND HOMILY ON THE ANNUAL CONVENTION OF THE CANON LAW SOCIETY OF NIGERIA

1.1 GREETINGS: Your Excellencies, My Lord Bishops, Very Reverend and Reverend Fathers, Reverend Sisters, and distinguished colleagues of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria (CLSN).

1.2 WELCOME: It is with deep ecclesial joy, profound gratitude, and a strong sense of canonical responsibility that I associate myself with others to warmly welcome all distinguished members of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria to this historic Annual Convention holding in the serene and culturally rich city of **Enugu** this 28th October 2026.

I humbly acknowledge with sincere appreciation the official invitation extended to me to deliver this keynote address. I consider it not merely an honour, but a sacred trust entrusted by a body of learned canonists whose commitment to the juridical life of the Church continues to shape ecclesial discipline in Nigeria. To speak on

Canonical Principles for Priests on their Participation in Politics is to engage a matter touching the very integrity of sacred ministry, ecclesial communion, and public witness.

The clarity of vision that has animated the Canon Law Society of Nigeria from its inception fidelity to the Magisterium, promotion of canonical scholarship, pastoral application of ecclesiastical law, and service to justice within the Church remains its defining strength. The Society has consistently upheld canon law not as a mere regulatory system but as a salvific instrument at the service of communion and mission.

Above all, we render all glory, honour, and thanksgiving to Almighty God, the Supreme Legislator of the Church, from whom all law derives its authority and toward whom all ecclesial governance must ultimately lead. Without His grace no juridical structure endures, without His wisdom no canonical mission bears fruit.

1.3 INTRODUCTION: At the eleventh hour of preparation for this convention I was instructed to combine the homily for this mass together with the keystone address.

I have chosen to present therefore first the homily before the keystone address, It is a task I hope to perform joyfully to the best of my ability.

1.4 THE TITLE OF THE HOMILY: Built on the Cornerstone of Justice: Canon Law as a Blueprint for Good Governance in Nigeria

We gather today under the crimson vestments of martyrdom to celebrate the Feast of Saints Simon and Jude, Apostles. We do so at a historic juncture—the 38th Annual Convention of our noble society. We are gathered to reflect deeply on a theme that sits at the core of our nation's survival and our Church's mission: Good Governance. As canonists, your laboratory is the intersection of law, justice, and pastoral charity. As we reflect on this theme within the context of Nigeria, and specifically here in the Onitsha Ecclesiastical Province spanning Enugu and its

environs, the readings of today offer us a profound structural blueprint.

1.5 In the First Reading, Saint Paul tells the Ephesians: "You are built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone" (Ephesians 2:20).

Just as the Church has an apostolic foundation, your presence here today rests on a visionary foundation laid decades ago. Established in 1982 by a direct mandate from the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria (CBCN), the Canon Law Society of Nigeria was born out of a critical need to establish a robust legal infrastructure for the Catholic Secretariat of Nigeria. We Shall come back to this for more details

1.6. THE GOSPEL BLUEPRINT: All-Night Prayer and Strategic Selection

Our Gospel reading from Luke presents a striking model of good governance. Before Jesus makes the most critical administrative decision of His earthly ministry—choosing the Twelve Apostles—He does something remarkable: "He

went out into the hills to pray; and all night he continued in prayer to God" (Luke 6:12).

Here lies the first lesson for governance in Nigeria and Enugu: True leadership requires deep spiritual and moral discernment.

In our secular environment, governance is often marred by impulsive decisions, nepotism, tribal alignments, and the rushed implementation of policies that do not serve the common good. Jesus spent the night seeking the Father's will. Good governance cannot be achieved through political expediency or legal shortcuts. It requires a foundational commitment to ethical reflection. As canon lawyers, when you advise bishops, religious institutes, and lay faithful, your legal interpretations must be seasoned by that same "all-night" spirit of prayerful discernment—ensuring that law always serves the salvation of souls (salusanimarum), which is the supreme law of the Church.

1.7 THE DIVERSITY OF THE TWELVE: Overcoming Division in Enugu and Beyond

Look at the list of those Jesus chose. He chose Simon, who was called the Zealot, and He chose Matthew (though not explicitly named in today's short passage, he is among the twelve). A Zealot was a radical nationalist who loathed Roman rule and anyone who collaborated with it. A tax collector was a Roman collaborator. Legally and socially, they were enemies. Yet, Jesus bound them together into one college.

Nigeria, and our local communities across Enugu, are deeply fractured by political polarization, zoning disputes, and socio-economic disparities. St. Paul reminds us: “You are no longer strangers and sojourners, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God” (Ephesians 2:19).

Good governance is inclusive. It breaks down walls of division. Canon law is a tool for equity; it ensures that every member of the Christian faithful—regardless of state of origin, gender, or social status—has rights that are protected and

duties that are clear. When the secular world around us divides, the Church's legal structure must demonstrate that unity, fair hearing, and justice are entirely possible.

1.8 POWER THAT HEALS: Authority as a Service

The Gospel concludes with Jesus coming down to a "level place". A massive crowd from Judea, Jerusalem, Tyre, and Sidon gathered because "power came forth from him and healed them all" (Luke 6:19).

This is the ultimate test of good governance: Does our authority heal, or does it wound?

In our nation, many experience governance as an oppressive force—a system that extracts resources but leaves the infrastructure broken, the youth unemployed, and the vulnerable unprotected. But in the Kingdom of God, authority is measured by its therapeutic capacity.

As canonists, your exercise of law must be healing. Whether you are handling marriage nullity cases, resolving temporal goods disputes,

or managing complex canonical disciplinary procedures, the goal must be the restoration of communion and the healing of the Body of Christ. Your legal expertise should be a refuge for the wrongly accused and a firm barrier against abuse and injustice.

1.9CONCLUSION:Being Living Stones

My dear canon lawyers, as you celebrate this 38th convention, remember that you are the architects tasked with keeping the walls of Christ's temple straight and true. Do not allow your canonical practice to become cold or mechanical. Infuse it with the zeal of Saint Simon and the unshakeable hope of Saint Jude—the patron of difficult cases.

Let us go forth from this convention resolved to make our legal expertise a blueprint for good governance, building a Church and a nation where no one is a stranger, justice flows like a river, and Christ remains our undisputed cornerstone.

Saints Simon and Jude, pray for us.

Amen

II. THE ORIGIN OF THE CANON LAW SOCIETY OF NIGERIA: FROM MEMORY, HISTORY, AND LEGACY SOURCES

11.1 This 2026 Convention invites us into a reflective journey not only toward present canonical challenges but also through the memory lane and historical pathway to the origin and legacy of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria itself.

It is fitting, therefore, to place on record, as a permanent canonical legacy, the humble origin of this Society.

The CLSN was born not out of institutional convenience but from an urgent pastoral need the need for competent canonical service within the Nigerian Church; the need for proper interpretation and application of ecclesiastical law; and the need for a forum where canon lawyers could collaborate in fidelity to the Church's juridical tradition.

From my weak and fading memory and extant records of meetings of Catholic Bishops Conference of Nigeria (CBCN), the following activities that mark the origin and growth of the CLSN can be highlighted:

11.2 The establishment of the legal department of the CBCN: Writing the first statutes of the CBCN was assigned to me as a young Bishop in 1975, the only member with a degree in Canon law. The Holy Spirit inspired me to assemble reputable canon law experts from the three Ecclesiastical Provinces of Nigeria to perform the task with me. The following experts were mobilized accordingly:

- From Kaduna Province – Fr Emmanuel Kure
- From Lagos Province – Rev. Fr. Colum Daley, OP, Rev, Fr. Etafo Benedict (Rector of SS Peter and Paul Major Seminary, Ibadan)
- From Onitsha Province – Msgr Hilary Okeke who later became the Bishop of Nnewi. Rev Msgr,

Cyriacus Mba (from Bigard Memorial Seminary Enugu). Rev, Fr. Asequo (Ikot Ekpene Major Seminary). These formed the nucleus of the association of Canon lawyers of Nigeria.

11.3: THE LEGACY OF CLSN

From modest gatherings of committed canonists, limited resources, and great zeal for ecclesial justice, the Society gradually evolved into a nationally respected professional body serving dioceses, tribunals, seminaries, and pastoral structures. Its history reflects perseverance, doctrinal fidelity, and unwavering commitment to the rule of law within the Church. The hard work of these experts gave birth to:-

a. The Canonical Establishment of the Departments of the Catholic Secretariat of Nigeria in 1975
b. Complimentary Norms to the 1983 Code of Canon Law for Nigeria (1989)

c. The Formulary to the Code of Canon Law by the CBCN. Edited by Bishop Anthony O. Gbuji. (1996)
d. The Canon Law Department CIWA was established by the competent bishops. Msgr. Hilary Okeke was presented by the CLSN to head the Department and work out its legal details.
e. The CLSN facilitated the establishment of the Regional Ecclesiastical tribunals in the provinces in Nigeria. (1999 – 2004).
f. Revised statutes of the CBCN (2000)

11.4: OFFICIAL RECOGNITION OF THE CLSN

In 1982 THE CANON LAW SOCIETY OF NIGERIA was officially approved by the CBCN. What began humbly as it were, through a period of conception, parturition and maturity has become an enduring ecclesial institution a testimony to divine providence, professional dedication, and the Church's ever-growing

juridical maturity in Nigeria. Ad multos Annos! to all members of the CLSN.

III. BRIEF REFLECTION ON THE 2026 CLSN CONVENTION THEME

111.1 The theme of this Convention addresses a delicate but crucial intersection between sacred ministry and political life an area where canonical discipline, pastoral prudence, and ecclesial identity must work in harmony.

111.2 Understanding the Theme

At its heart, the theme emphasizes the canonical boundaries that safeguard priestly ministry from political entanglement while preserving the Church's prophetic voice in society.

111.3 Central Message

The priest, by sacred ordination, is configured to Christ as Shepherd and servant of unity. Canon law therefore restricts clerical involvement in partisan politics not to silence moral witness, but to protect:

- the universality of the Church,

- the neutrality required for pastoral service to all,
- the integrity of sacred ministry and
- the unity of the People of God

111.4 Key Challenges

1. Increasing politicization of clergy
2. Public scandal and ecclesial division
3. Confusion between social advocacy and party alignment
4. External pressures from ethnic, economic, and ideological forces
5. Weak canonical formation and enforcement

The theme therefore calls the Church back to canonical prudence with wisdom as a guide for pastoral integrity and ecclesial credibility in public life. We patiently wait for the scholarly and elaborate papers and intervention during the the course of this memorable convention.

IV. THE PASTORAL SERVICE OF CANNON LAW

IV.1 The work of canon lawyers is not merely legal or administrative. Canon law is a sacred service placed at the disposal of the Church for justice, order, communion, pastoral charity, and the spiritual welfare of Christ's faithful. For this reason, every canon lawyer must always remember the supreme law of the Church: *salusanimarum* the salvation of souls, as expressed in Canon 1752.

When canon law is applied with truth, charity, and pastoral wisdom, it becomes an instrument of healing, guidance, discipline, and unity. I therefore encourage members of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria to continue to see their vocation not only as legal expertise, but also as pastoral service to the Church and to the people of God.

As I express my gratitude, I also wish to place before the members of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria two other important pastoral areas that I discovered in the pastoral ministry as a

canon lawyer deserve serious attention: Evangelizing catechesis in relation to canon law and inculturation from a canon law perspective.

IV. EVANGELIZING CATECHESIS

IV.I The first important area is evangelizing catechesis. This is rooted in the Lord's mandate to all: "Go proclaim the goodnews and teach all nations" (Mt 28: 19-20). The CJC under the Teaching Office of the Church fully elaborates on this. (cf CIC Book III). The Church in Nigeria continues to need deeper formation of the faithful. It is not enough for Catholics to belong to the Church by name alone. The faith must be known, loved, lived, defended, and witnessed in daily life.

- Evangelizing catechesis means the ongoing formation of every Catholic to know Christ better, love Him more deeply, serve Him more faithfully, and bear credible witness to Him. The crisis confronting the Church today is not merely juridical disobedience but

inadequate formation of conscience. Canon law is often violated not from malice but from ignorance of ecclesial identity, mission, and discipline. “My people perish for lack of Knowledge” (Hosea 4:6).

- Every baptized Christian is called, according to his or her state in life, to become a missionary disciple, to teach the Catechism of the Catholic Church (CCC).
- Canon lawyers also have a role in this mission. Through their knowledge and service, they help safeguard sound doctrine, strengthen ecclesial structures, protect the rights and duties of the faithful, and support the teaching mission of the Church. I therefore invite every member of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria to support evangelizing catechesis with renewed zeal, especially in collaboration with the bishops and dioceses across Nigeria.

IV.2. INCULTURATION

Inculturation remains a vital task for the Church in Nigeria. The Gospel must take root in the life, language, customs, and values of the people. At the same time, culture must be purified, enlightened, and transformed by the Gospel of Christ. This work requires sound doctrine, pastoral wisdom, and careful canonical guidance.

Canon lawyers have an important role to play in helping the Church discern what may be accepted, what must be purified, what should be corrected, and what must be rejected for the good of the faithful. I therefore encourage the members of the Society to take seriously the task of assisting the Church in the proper inculturation of the faith among the people of God in Nigeria.

In this regard, I acknowledge with appreciation the contribution of Rev. Fr. Michael Chime, JCD, whose work has shown how canon lawyers can engage fruitfully with the question of inculturation, especially from a deep study of my

thesis on **Title societies among the Igbo of Nigeria in the light of canonical legislation**. Such reflection remains important for the Church's mission in our local context.

V. CONCLUSION

All canonical activity, all catechetical formation, and all ecclesial discipline converge toward one supreme canonical principle of the Church:

Salus animarum suprema lex est
The salvation of souls is the supreme law.

If the Canon Law Society of Nigeria remains anchored in this truth, its work will not merely regulate ecclesial life but will renew the Church's mission, sanctify her ministers, and strengthen her witness in society. Eternal salvation of souls will flow like a river. (Cfr Ps 78:16)

The Lord cries out today to all the members of the CLSN: Whom shall I send? Who will go?

I hear each and everyone answer: “Here I am Lord, send me” (Is. 8:6). Let me lead you in a sonorous response

May the Lord sustain you with his amazing grace and grant you success in all your deliberations at this convention.

Thanks.

+A.O Gbuji

Bishop Emeritus Enugu Diocese

28th OCTOBER, 2026.